

Farm Bill Conference: Protect Food-as-Medicine & Local Food Funding

From Jim Rusk, Founder, Aridon LLC — building a technology campus in Farmington, NM — September 2026

Who we are

Aridon is developing the **Farm-to-Health Network**: the "missing middle" between regenerative producers and healthcare produce-prescription programs — aggregation, nutrient-density verification, cold chain, and lender-ready records. Our planned pilot: **200 patients, weekly produce boxes, 6 months, Four-State region (KS/MO/OK/AR)**. Federal momentum is real: the Indian Health Service recently funded **\$3.5M in tribal produce-prescription pilots**.

What we ask of the conference committee

- **Protect and grow GusNIP** (produce prescriptions + nutrition incentives). The House bill continues GusNIP but flat-funds it. A 600+ organization coalition is pushing expansion through the GusNIP Expansion and Improvement Acts. Flat funding strands programs like ours at pilot scale.
- **Protect the new "Local Farmers Feeding Our Communities" program** (House bill, up to **\$200M/year** for state, local, and tribal food purchasing). This is the procurement backbone regional food hubs need.
- **Support the Senate's State Conservation Assistance Program** (~\$50M/year for state and tribal soil-health and water-quality programs). Regenerative transitions need working-lands support, not just commodity support.

Why it matters

- Diet-related disease drives U.S. healthcare costs; produce prescriptions are among the few interventions with both clinical signal and farmer income attached.
- Every federal dollar for verified-density local procurement multiplies: patient health, producer premiums, and rural aggregation jobs.
- We are not asking for a carve-out — only that conference **not cut** the nutrition-incentive and local-food titles, and that GusNIP funding grow with demonstrated demand.

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We stay out of the SNAP and animal-welfare fights; this ask is limited to food-as-medicine and local-food provisions.